

CARS AND TRUCKS

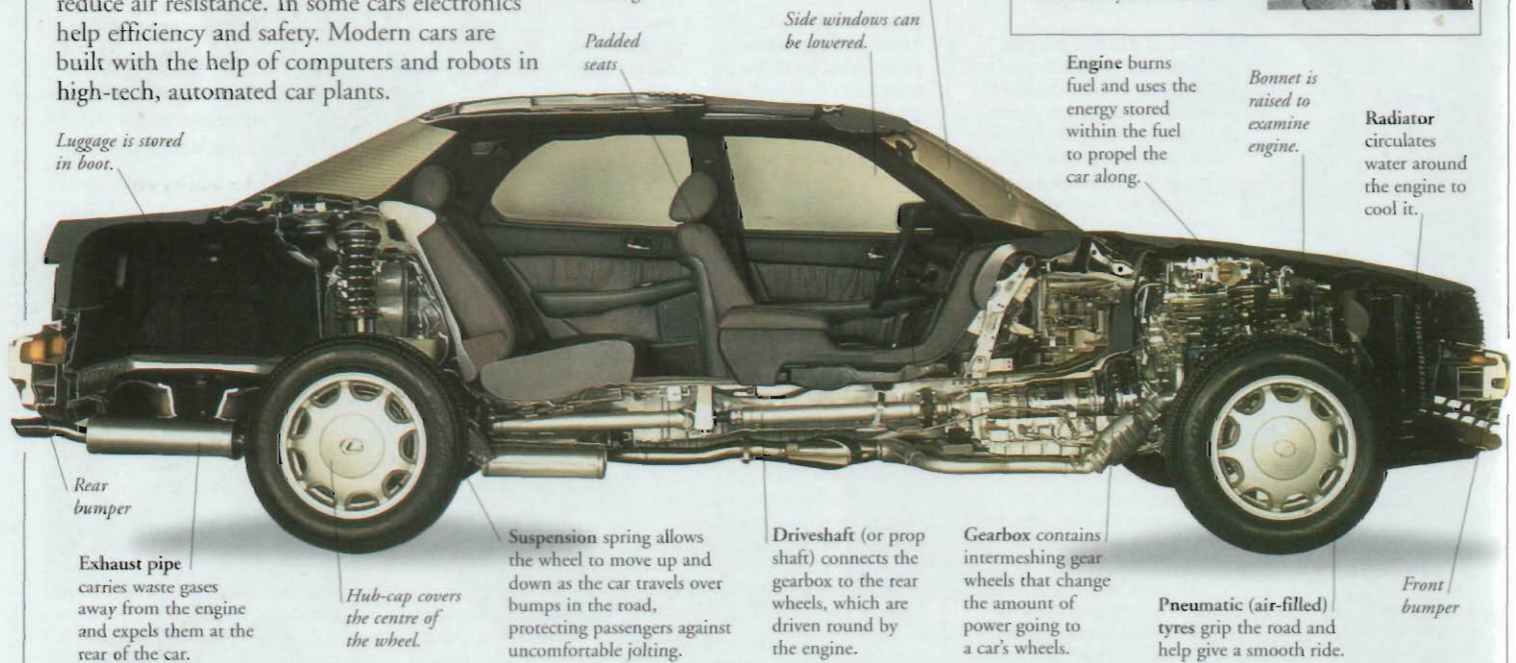


OF ALL THE DIFFERENT FORMS of transport, cars have the biggest effect on our lives. Cars give people the freedom to go where they like, when they like – with some types of car you don't even need a road.

Trucks are used for long-distance haulage and for performing many specialized tasks, such as fire-fighting. In parts of the world where there are no railways, trucks offer the only way of transporting goods. But cars and trucks create pollution. Because there are now so many of them on the roads, the world's cities have become clogged with traffic, and the air that many of us breathe is poisoned with traffic fumes.

Modern cars

Efficiency, safety, and comfort are the most important features of a modern car, as well as minimal air pollution from exhaust fumes. To be efficient, cars need engines that use as little fuel as possible, and a streamlined shape to reduce air resistance. In some cars electronics help efficiency and safety. Modern cars are built with the help of computers and robots in high-tech, automated car plants.



A Benz Motor Wagen of 1886

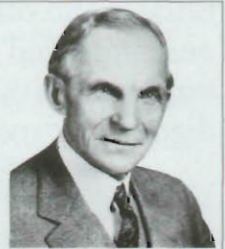


Early cars

Early cars were called "horseless carriages". They were made by manufacturers of horse-drawn carriages and coaches, and had the same large wheels, high driver's seat, and suspension. They were powered by a single-cylinder petrol engine, which could reach a top speed of 15 kmh (9 mph).

Henry Ford

American engineer Henry Ford (1863–1947) formed the Ford Motor Company in 1903. In 1908, Ford launched the Model T. It was made cheaply on a factory assembly line and sold by the million.



Luggage is carried in the boot.



Family saloon

Aerodynamic design enhances speed performance.



Sports car

People carrier/MPV



Three rows of detachable seats

Formula 1 racer



Wing

Driver's cockpit

Types of cars

The most popular car is the saloon, which has an enclosed passenger compartment and a separate rear space for luggage. Hatchbacks are saloons with a large rear door and a folding back seat for extra luggage space.

Sports cars

Sports cars are designed to be stylish, fast, and fun. Some sports cars are convertibles, which have a flexible roof that can be folded down so that passengers can enjoy driving in the open air. Luxury convertibles have roofs that open and close automatically.

People carrier

One of the latest types of car is the people carrier, or multi-purpose vehicle (MPV). This vehicle is a cross between a saloon car and a minibus. People carriers are very versatile, with at least six seats and plenty of space for luggage. They are perfect for outings or holidays.

Racing car

Some cars are purpose-built for racing. They have a very powerful engine, wide tyres, and a low, wide body for stability around fast corners. An aerodynamic "wing" on the back helps keep the car on the road at high speeds. Saloons can be converted into racing or rallying cars.